

Writing Book Reviews

Planning a Book Review

Purpose: To review a book and inform other readers.

Use this sheet to plan your book review. Use bullet points or short sentences to organise your ideas.

Book Title: _____

Background Information

Begin with a short summary. This section should only be a few sentences and may include:

- Background information about the author, when the book was written and what was happening at the time the book was written. This gives context to the reader.
- A quote that stuck out to you from the book.
- An explanation of an important word or phrase used in the book, to help the reader understand.
- Interesting facts about the author or the book itself.

Example:

- Lewis Carroll's real name was Charles Lutwidge Dodgson. He was born in 1832 in England.
- He had ten siblings — seven sisters and three brothers.
- He used to make up games to keep his siblings entertained, and began publishing a magazine for his family called "Rectory Magazines" and all his family had to contribute.
- He was shy and got bullied at school. He also had an illness which caused him to go deaf in one ear.

Alice's Adventures in Wonderland

- Written by Lewis Carroll in 1865.
- Originally told as a tale to three children he was looking after one day, and one enjoyed the stories so much she asked him to write them down.
- The story was read by a popular children's author of the time whose own son liked it so much that Dodgson (Carroll) had it published.
- When Dodgson died in 1898, Alice's Adventures in Wonderland was the most popular children's book in England.

Information About the Book

This section should be just under half of your review. Include information about things like:

- General Information
- Plot (no spoilers!)
- Characters
- Theme
- Setting

Example:

- Alice falls down a rabbit hole and ends up in Wonderland. On her adventures she meets many strange characters and has some very odd experiences, such as playing croquet with a queen and getting advice from a caterpillar.
- Alice is the main character, she is probably about 10 years old, thinks she is quite clever and talks about what she has learned in school a lot. She likes her cat.
- Other characters include the White Rabbit, the Cheshire Cat, the Queen of Hearts,

the Duchess, the Mock Turtle, the Mad Hatter, and the March Hare. Some of the characters have their own chapters in the book.

- There is no clear theme, it really is just about Alice having adventures in Wonderland.
- The setting is Wonderland — nothing is as it seems and everything is exactly the opposite of what you'd expect. "Curiouser and curiouser" is a quote that sums it up.

Your Opinion/Analysis

This section should be about half of your review. You could include things like:

- Why would others enjoy this book?
- What did you enjoy or not enjoy about it?
- What age group and type of reader would it be good for?
- Did it engage you emotionally — did you laugh or cry, or think about something in the book for days?
- What did you like or dislike about the writing style? Was it funny? Hard to follow? Engaging? Casual? Formal?
- How well do you think the author achieved what they were trying to do?
- Did the book feel complete or did it feel like it was missing key elements?
- How does it compare to similar books that you have read?

Example:

- Formal language, which can be hard to read because of the time it was written.
- Enjoyable because there is no real drama — it's like lots of mini stories and no massive problem, except that Alice might want to get home.

- I enjoyed it because it was absolutely ridiculous and sometimes made no sense — good to be reminded to be silly sometimes.
- Good for readers around 10+ because of the language and vocabulary. Younger children would enjoy it being read to them at bedtime.
- Lewis Carroll set out to entertain children and he did well, since his book has been one of the most popular children's stories for more than a hundred years — so popular Disney made a film.
- Sometimes I felt like it was missing a standard narrative structure, but that's because I usually read fantasy novels where the protagonist is on a quest. I did enjoy that it was just ridiculous though.

Rating

Give the book a rating. Commonly this is out of 5 or 10.

Example:

I give this book 4/5 stars.